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[00:15:21] The House will come to order. Members, please take your seats. Head page. The House is now in session. All persons not entitled to privileges of the floor, please retire to the gallery.

[00:15:37] The members will rise and be led in prayer by Dr. George Anderson, Senior Pastor, Presbyterian Church, Roanoke, and remain standing for the Pledge of Allegiance of the Flag of the United States of America, which will be led by the Delegate from Alexandria, Delegate Herring. Let us pray.

[00:15:55] Holy One of justice and mercy, we bow before you mindful of the weight and privilege of leadership. You have entrusted this body with shaping laws for a diverse and spirited commonwealth. Grant these delegates grace to listen carefully, to speak truthfully, and to act with integrity.

[00:16:15] May their work continue to set an example worthy of this chamber, showing that conviction and civility can dwell together and that disagreement need not become disdain. In negotiation, grant them creativity, and in compromise, grant them wisdom, for we know that even imperfect agreements can advance the common good.

[00:16:36] Bless this commonwealth, our nation, and the world, that the inheritance of coming generations may be greater justice, peace, and kindness in the way we live together. Amen.

[00:17:10] The members will answer the roll call by indicating their presence on the electronic voting board.

[00:17:33] Clerk will close the roll. Mr. Speaker, a quorum is present. Pursuant to House Rule 3, I've examined and approved the General House of Delegates for February 19, 2026.

[00:17:50] Most of the resolutions under Rule 39 pursuant to the provisions of Rule 40 are now in order. Does the clerk have any additional announcements or communications? No, sir, not at this time. Accordingly in this first portion of the morning hour, pursuant to House Rule 40, speaker, request to use your request to speak button for the agenda items listed for reference up on the voting board.

[00:18:07] Delegate from Richmond, Delegate Carr. Thank you, Mr. Speaker. I rise for an introduction and then a motion. The delegate has the floor. Thank you, sir. Thank you, members and colleagues.

[00:18:22] Joining us today in the gallery are members from the Junior League of Richmond, and I ask them to please stand now. The Junior League celebrates its centennial, marking 100 years of service to the greater Richmond community. Founded in 1926 by 59 young women, the JLR has advanced women's leadership and driven social impact through volunteerism, professional development, and community action.

[00:18:48] I'm proud to say I'm a sustaining member of the Richmond Junior League and know that But some of my colleagues have enjoyed shopping at their consignment store, the clothes rack here in Kerrytown. There's a strong tradition of maternal and child advocacy in the Junior League of Richmond, including lobbyists, lobbying for the Mother's Aid Bill, which helped establish Well Baby and Immunology clinics across the city, and cemented Virginia as a participant in one of the nation's first major federal welfare programs.

[00:19:18] During World War II, the Junior League raised $150,000 over $2 million today for war bonds and supported service members through weekly programs. In the Richmond we know today, the League has played a foundational role by supporting the creation of the Science Museum of Virginia, Children's Theatre of Richmond, Greater Richmond Child Advocacy Center, and the Senior Center of Richmond.

[00:19:42] The League continues to value women helping women through partnerships with local nonprofits focused on addressing domestic violence, job opportunity, foster care, under-resourced public schools, affordable housing, and improving access to child care.

[00:19:57] Please join me in honoring the Junior League of Richmond for a century of service, leadership, and community impact, and welcome them today. Welcome.

[00:20:16] Welcome to the Capitol today. Thank you, Mr. Speaker. And with that said, I would like to move that we take House Joint Resolution 142 up out of order, and I ask that we move its adoption. Clerk will report a resolution. House Joint Resolution 142 commending the Junior League of Richmond.

[00:20:33] All those in favor of adopting House Joint Resolution 142 commending the Junior League of Richmond will say aye. Those opposed, no. The motion is agreed to. Congratulations. The delegate from Roanoke, Delegate McNamara. Mr. Speaker, I rise for the purpose of an introduction. The delegate has the floor. Thank you, Mr. Speaker.

[00:20:56] Mr. Speaker, leading us in prayer this morning was Dr. George C. Anderson in the back of our galley. Gallery, senior pastor of Second Presbyterian Church in Roanoke City. There he serves as the

seventh senior pastor in the history of Second Presbyterian Church, where he has been preaching since 1998. In recent years, Second Presbyterian raised more than $1.7 million to renovate shelter houses for community members in need, as well as to support the Presbyterian Community Center that serves Roanoke residents.

[00:21:33] Pastor Anderson is a graduate of St. Andrews Presbyterian College in Laurenburg, North Carolina, and Union Presbyterian Seminary here in Richmond. Dr. Anderson is involved in every aspect of church life with an emphasis on preaching, teaching, visiting, and staff oversight.

[00:21:54] Pastor Anderson and his wife Millie have three wonderful daughters, Paige, Rachel, and Virginia, and two beautiful grandchildren. I ask you all to join me in giving him a very warm house welcome.

[00:22:17] Welcome, welcome to the Capitol, and thank you for that wonderful prayer this morning. Thank you, Mr. Speaker. Delegate from Chesapeake, Delegate Leftwich. Mr. Speaker, I rise for a motion.

[00:22:35] The delegate has the floor. And I'd like to speak to that motion after I make it. Mr. Speaker, I move that when we adjourn today, we move, we adjourn in the memory and honor of Downer Road Delegate Barry D. Knight.

[00:22:53] The delegate has the floor. Speaking of the motion. I hope I can get through this. While we will forever know Barry, a delegate, Barry Knight, as Delegate Knight, or the Honorable Barry D. Knight, or as former chair of the Appropriations Committee, first and foremost, he was a friend, and that is how I choose to remember him.

[00:23:18] Barry's life was full of passion and hobbies. He loved flying his helicopter, and when we would go up, he would go through all the safety protocols and safety checks, regardless of whether everything was apparently just fine. During the summer, he spent time in Corrova, which is an area of the beach that's all sand roads, all four-wheel drive.

[00:23:40] And we were coming up on an intersection one day, and he said, Jay, I want you to look to the right. I'm going to look to the left. And if you see anybody coming, let me know. If not, I'm going to gun it through the intersection. I said, well, why, Barry? Why don't we just pull up the intersection like normal people do and stop and look?

[00:23:57] He goes, I don't have any brakes. Apparently, safety protocols for aviation did not apply to vehicles in the Outer Banks. He had a beautiful home in Marathon with his cousin, Cousin Rudy. He hunted and fished all over the U.S., but his favorite was bone fishing in the Bahamas.

[00:24:17] And he rode his Harley in all lower 48 states. When someone passes, you always have questions, things you wish you had asked that person during their life. Mine would be, Barry, have you ever been a paid actor in a Dos Equis commercial?

[00:24:35] With his weathered face, beard, mustache, and exploits, he certainly was an interesting man. If I stop now, you would think Barry lived a pretty comfortable life financially, perhaps in his later years. But that wasn't until he scratched and clawed his way up the ladder of life.

[00:24:56] I'll touch on that a bit more in a few minutes. But I'll simply say what I just described was about living, sharing his blessings with others, and bringing people together. He routinely had large dinners at his house in Pungo.

[00:25:12] He had an open door in Corovo, a marathon, always invited people to stop by anytime, announced or unannounced. He was always ready to share a meal, cocktail, cigar, and most certainly laughter. He routinely took young kids on helicopter rides, showing them the northern beaches of the Outer Banks, showing them the remnants of old wrecks and sandbars that paralleled the shore.

[00:25:38] More than once, he medevaced an injured person to Virginia Beach, and at more unfortunate times, when someone was missing in the surf, he joined the search by air. Barry was a generous man, sharing his gifts he had been blessed with.

[00:25:55] Not long ago, I was in a duck blind with six other people. The seventh was in the home cooking breakfast because he was smart enough to sit in the middle of a body of water at 13 degrees. I looked around and realized that I didn't know any of these guys three or four years ago.

[00:26:13] I met them all through Barry. On a recent quail hunt, I was with a different six guys, and the proprietor asked, how do y'all know each other? We all kind of looked up and said in unison pretty much the same thing.

[00:26:30] Barry's the common denominator. We all met through him. I was on a fishing trip last year with yet a different group, and I had the same realization. I could go on. The point is, Barry had a gift of bringing people together and making friends, all predicated upon integrity, trust, and loyalty.

[00:26:54] His word was his bond. In remembering Barry, who was affectionately referred to as the mayor of Pungo, it is quintessential to understand where he came from. Barry's roots in the Commonwealth run deep, and he traced his lineage to Thomas Savage.

[00:27:10] He immigrated at age 13 as a cabin boy to Christopher Newport on the first supply mission to Jamestown in 1608. At some point, Thomas was, and I quote, gifted to Chief Powhatan. And this is how the story goes according to Barry.

[00:27:28] A couple Englishmen at Chief Powhatan were sitting around, probably drinking corn mash brewed by Delegate Ballard's predecessors. One Englishman said, you know, it would be really cool if we take an Indian back to England. Powhatan paused, mused, and agreed that the Motaki could travel to England, but he insisted, in exchange, that his tribe hold an Englishman.

[00:27:57] The Englishman thought, looked around, and said, sure, take the cabin boy. They thought to themselves, nobody's going to miss him. But Tom, like any good farmer from Pungo, took these lemons, life dealt him, and made lemonade. He learned the native language and culture and became an important resource for communication and Indian-English relations.

[00:28:19] Tom lived a fruitful life and is buried at Bruton Parish Episcopal Church Cemetery in Williamsburg. Although I find this genealogy interesting, there's a reason I tell you this. Through unforeseen circumstances and unfamiliar culture and language, Tom Savage brought people with different backgrounds together.

[00:28:42] More than 350 years later, and then more than 60 miles from Jamestown, whether you're in Pungo or Richmond, Barry did the same thing through his personal business and public life. Barry attended Kempstow High School in Virginia Beach and earned his undergraduate master's and doctoral degree in the College of Life and Hard Knocks.

[00:29:04] If Barry were here now, he'd probably tell you he didn't have the best male role model in the home growing up and acknowledged that he often wondered how the family would make ends meet. Although Barry had a devoted mother and siblings, in part, he began fending for himself at the age of 14 when he began working eye jobs as a farmhand for Mr. Brown.

[00:29:32] After high school, he continued with farm work, supplemented his income during the summer as a long-haul truck driver. By his account, the first house he rented wasn't fit for habitation, indicating that within a month or two of him moving out, it collapsed.

[00:29:48] And I mean, it literally fell to the ground. Not bulldozed, but fell to the ground. Nevertheless, he was happy, having said, it was a roof over my head when I needed one, and as only a budget guy could appreciate, it was cheap. All Barry knew was how to work, and he worked hard.

[00:30:06] At the age of 26, he bought his first farm. No bank would loan him money, but Mr. Brown did, because he knew Barry's work ethic and believed in him. This gives rise to my second question. I'd like to know the first name of the man who helped Barry become the person he became.

[00:30:29] Barry always, to the day he passed, referred to this man as Mr. Brown. Surely he had respect, admiration, and love for this man. And what seemed unimportant before has been curious now.

[00:30:47] As we mourn here, I'm sure they are talking hops, parlies, and hogs in heaven. Barry went from working several jobs to one, farming, where he worked 12 hours a day, six days a week, and half a day on Sunday for decades, until he gradually eased out of the farming business and sold much of the 640 acres of farmland he had accumulated.

[00:31:13] It was through this hog business that Barry honed his skill to haggle and negotiate. After one transaction, he was sitting at the closing table, and the buyer's lawyer looked at him and said, are you happy with the sale? And Barry replied, well, it's not exactly what I was expecting, but yes, I'm happy. What he didn't say out loud was that the purchase price was exactly two times more than what he would have accepted. Barry brought his craftiness and life experiences to the House of Deluxe in 2009, becoming chair of the House Appropriations from 2022 to 2024,

[00:31:49] and has received accolades from governors, former chairs of appropriation, and others as having masterful knowledge of and skillfully crafting Virginia's billion-dollar budget, leading one executive of a Fortune 500 company to observe that in the financial sector, companies typically focus on numbers, but that Barry focused on strategy. I could go on about Barry's contributions to Virginia Beach, Chesapeake, Norfolk, Hampton Roads, and the Commonwealth, the roads, bridges, mergers, and buildings that all have its fingerprints, but what I admire and care for

[00:32:23] the most about Barry is his friendship and his devotion to family. Barry, in his words, married his one love and beautiful wife, Paul. Together they raised three boys, Hunter, Kyle, and Forrest,

[00:32:53] all three of whom have the pleasure of knowing, all of whom are fine men. They do have the same and have started a new generation of knights, and these values mirror Barry and Paul's faith, integrity, loyalty, and work ethic. Meaningful relationships, whether it's with a spouse, a child, a family member, a neighbor, or a colleague, require time and effort. I think,

[00:33:29] and I think we all try to build those relationships, but it just comes natural to some people. Personality is infectious, and their bandwidth to interact with others is limitless. Barry was one of these

people. Although I call Barry one of my best friends, for me that probably describes a group of maybe a handful of people but barry had dozens if not a hundred or more best friends he just had a gift he was the one person who could tell a clean joke make people laugh as much the 20th time as he told it as he did the first time he told it his jokes were so corny but he became

[00:34:08] so excited and tickled with himself you start laughing before he ever got to the bunch line barry and i started out as two guys in the same party representing portions of chesapeake we got They know each other, they had little caucus members, and later served on the same committee.

[00:34:26] These things led to many conversations, which led to hanging out and socializing together. Without even realizing that we became friends. We hunted, fished, and carried on like guys do. You know, a little bit of machoism. And one day, one of us used the F word.

[00:34:43] You know, the thing guys have a hard time talking about. We talked about our faith. And Barry was a man of faith. He is a believer, and he knew Christ as a Savior. And while his family lost a husband, father, and brother, the Commonwealth lost a phenomenal and effective leader, and countless people lost a friend.

[00:35:08] I know he's in a better place, free of pain and the troubles of this world, and has a new set of friends in heaven, all of whom, no doubt, will enjoy his company and laugh at the same corny jokes we laughed at. Mr. Speaker, before I yield the floor to the delegate from Richmond City, Delegate McQuinn, a final thought, I find solace in a passage penned by Dietrich Bonhoeffer, a German pastor, a theologian.

[00:35:35] No one has yet believed in God and the kingdom of God. No one has yet heard about the realm of the resurrection, not been homesick from that hour, waiting and looking forward joyfully to being released from bodily existence.

[00:35:51] That life only really begins when it ends here on earth, and all that is here is only the prologue. So to my friend, everyone's friend, I say ting-a-ling, and Godspeed, my good friend.

[00:36:08] The delegate from Prince William, Delegatory. Yes, Mr. Speaker, I'd like to speak to the motion made by the delegate from Chesapeake. The delegate has the floor. It was 2010.

[00:37:01] I had a helicopter pilot and a gentleman who raised hogs, who had this very healthy mustache. And for 16 years, we served together.

[00:37:27] General Laws, and we went back and forth over the last six years being chair of the House Appropriations Committee and on rules. Mr. Speaker has a saying that he often shares with me when we talk in private.

[00:37:47] He says, we just got to get people to run the play. Delegate Knight and others who served in general laws and house appropriations, we would come together in our meetings and often congregate and talk about how we were going to run the play to make sure that we understood what we needed to do in order to advance legislation, in order to represent and to support the citizens of the Commonwealth of Virginia.

[00:38:24] What many don't understand is that sometimes when you're Democrat or Republican, you have to come together and learn how to run the play for the betterment of the Commonwealth. And that is what we did. Mr. Speaker, oftentimes each day when I rise, I start my day listening to this song.

[00:38:51] Great is thy faithfulness. And some of the lyrics, great is thy faithfulness. Morning by morning, new mercies I see. All I have needed, thy hand has provided.

[00:39:09] Great is thy faithfulness, Lord, unto me. Great was God's faithfulness to Barry Knight. Morning by morning, God allowed him to see new mercies.

[00:39:26] In all he needed, God hand provided for him. Great was God's faithfulness to delegate Barry Knight, my friend, Delores McQuinn's friend, our friend.

[00:39:44] Thank you, Mr. Speaker. The delegate from Powhatan. Delegate Ware. Thank you, Mr. Speaker. I join my colleagues in speaking of Barry Knight. The delegate has the floor. Barry's near neighbor in Virginia Beach, former Attorney General Jason Meares, captured the big picture, citing Teddy Roosevelt's son, who when his father passed said this, a great lion has passed.

[00:40:18] I'm not sure I've ever known a man of greater accomplishment or less pretense. than Barry Knight. He was a delegate for 17 years. He served on the committees that have been alluded to, general laws, rules, ACNR, CCT, and on appropriations where he loomed larger and larger into the role of chairman. It is somehow fitting that he entered eternity on budget weekend.

[00:40:48] He knew the waterfront of his beloved Virginia Beach, just as he came to know the complicated and interwoven waterfront of the Appropriations Territory. He came over time to an unparalleled command of its nuances.

[00:41:06] And in that role, he befriended an array of folks, again, something that's been alluded to, and that array included people as different as Governor Yunkin and Senator Lucas. Amen. My first memory of Barry was him dropping his helicopter on a lawn at the 4-H Center at Smith Mountain Lake.

[00:41:30] He and Paula and their three boys were attending that year's legislative trail ride. He could make an entrance. He would show up in that helicopter later at my little Powhatan courthouse backyard for an event.

[00:41:46] And when he did, it became a modest Facebook sensation in my little corner of the world. But Barry could drive more than the helicopter. He could drive just about anything he sat in the seat of. He drove, as was mentioned, his Harley Davidson.

[00:42:03] He drove a fuel oil tanker, a semi-long haul truck, a bulldozer, an excavator. I can't even name some of the other things he drove. And what's interesting is the only one that he actually took lessons for was the helicopter.

[00:42:19] With the rest, he just climbed up on the seat or in the cab, fiddled with the instruments a little while, and off he went to drive them and operate them. But it was on his farm that the man in full appeared.

[00:42:35] He knew and respected and loved the lineaments of the land, its waterways, and the buildings that came to serve him and his pigs. He was a hog farmer. And I suppose that's why, while he took life seriously, he never took himself too seriously.

[00:42:56] I want you to picture this. You're at a reception, one of the receptions we go to around here. And a new acquaintance comes up to you and he asks, what do you do for a living outside the General Assembly? Hog farmer. Well, that's what it was for Barry.

[00:43:14] It's also why he could see a project through, overcome roadblocks, and figure a way to solve often cross-grained problems, because that is the daily life of a farmer.

[00:43:31] Comments yesterday alluded properly to his steadiness. He could be immovable, but he was only immovable after he'd heard out alternative and often conflicting views on things. He possessed a hard-earned capacity for judgment on property and policy and people.

[00:43:57] In his chosen calling and in his life generally, Barry lived close to the fundamental things. You've heard from his early years how he loved to hunt and fish, and although his later accomplishments allowed him to hunt and fish in far-flung places, from Marathon in the Florida Keys to Casco Bay near Portland, Maine, from the forests of Virginia to the fields of South Dakota.

[00:44:23] In keeping with those pastimes, he was an inveterate storyteller and joke teller. And sometime later, we can talk about some of those. Though he would travel, he was born and remained a son of Pungo, a rural community in Virginia Beach whose location and his district's location are in the very furthest, southeasternmost corner of this commonwealth of Virginia.

[00:44:49] He did have to travel five miles to Creed to find Paula, and they were married together over 40 years. Together, they raised three very impressive sons. I hope you have the chance to meet them along the way.

[00:45:05] And how many fathers do you know who've been asked to be the best man at their son's wedding? His faith, which he did not broadcast, but which he did live, was nurtured in the good Lord's great outdoors and in the Oak Grove Baptist Church.

[00:45:26] He was a patriotic Virginian, and you've heard of his Jamestown ancestor. And I still recall, because I was there with him, his pleasure and his astonishment to be named to the Jamestown Yorktown Foundation Board. One of the greatest honors of my life has been to be Barry Knight's seatmate, which I have been for more than a decade, and to call him a friend.

[00:45:59] The great Georgian writer Flannery O'Connor wrote, The writer operates at a peculiar crossroads where time and place and eternity somehow meet. Ms. Flannery's words also apply to the farmer who operates at the peculiar crossroads where time and place and eternity somehow meet.

[00:46:23] Delegate Barry D. Knight entered eternity yesterday. And so, Mr. Speaker, I renew the motion of my colleagues that when the House adjourns today, it adjourns in the honor and memory of Delegate Barry D. Knight.

[00:46:40] The delegates from Chesapeake, Delegate Leftwich, the delegate from Prince William, Delegate Torian, and the delegate from Powhatan, Delegate Webb, move that when the House adjourned today, it do so in the honor and memory of the Honorable Barry D. Knight.

[00:46:56] All those in favor of the motion shall rise. The motion is agreed to.

[00:47:20] Delegate from Virginia Beach. Delegate, ask you.

[00:47:39] Thank you, Mr. Speaker. Mr. Speaker, I rise for the point of introduction. Delegate has the floor. Thank you, Mr. Speaker. Mr. Speaker, here today in the gallery, we have the senior adults living triumphantly of New Jerusalem Ministries. If they please rise.

[00:47:58] Mr. Speaker, these dedicated members are led by our pastor, Dr. Veronica Coleman. New Jerusalem Ministries is the pillar of its community by bringing people together through fellowship, worship, and empowerment. Pastor Dr. Veronica Coleman and New Jerusalem Ministries grow through the study of God's word and serve in a valuable part of our community.

[00:48:19] It is an honor to have them here today. My mother is up there as well, and I hope that the body will wish them a warm house welcome.

[00:48:36] Welcome. Welcome to the Capitol today. The delegate from Colonial Heights, Delegate Cherry. Mr. Speaker, I rise for an announcement. Delegate has the floor. Mr. Speaker, even amongst the heaviness of today, it is a day of celebration for some, not only here in Virginia, but around the nation. Today, Mr. Speaker, is National Cherry Pie Day.

[00:48:56] A few facts. Cherry trees made their way to Virginia in the 17th century. According to the USDA, there are 139 farms spanning 112 acres growing sweet, sweet cherries here in the Commonwealth. 67 farms on 24 acres growing sour cherries that we use in pies.

[00:49:13] The majority of our cherry production lies in the southwest corner in Carroll and Patrick counties. I do need to acknowledge my colleague from Charlottesville. today for bringing this day to my attention and ensuring that we were so ready to celebrate. She even wore her cherry red shirt today, I will acknowledge.

[00:49:31] Mr. Speaker, with my cherry tie, my cherry cup, my cherry socks, I enjoined my colleagues to please join me in the break room for some cherry pie. Thank you, Mr. Speaker. Thank you, Delegate Cherry.

[00:49:49] Delegate from Henrico, Delegate McQuinn. Thank you, Mr. Speaker. Mr. Speaker, I rise for an announcement. Delegate has the floor. Mr. Speaker, I want to arise to remind my colleagues about the 18th annual Capitol Square Classic, House versus the Senate, which is February the 23rd on Monday.

[00:50:09] The doors open at 5 p.m. and 7 p.m. is tip off at the Segal Center. But I also want to remind us that we're here and this is all about raising funds for the Massey Cancer Center, comprehensive cancer center.

[00:50:26] And I'm hoping that this year, particularly as we have heard all that has been said about our colleague today, that we would give more now than we've ever given to help fight this good fight. It is a fight, and anyone who's diagnosed or who's struggling with cancer know the fight their families may be in, the communities.

[00:50:50] So I'm asking you to please give the event is on Monday. We need you to please dig deep, as they say in the church, and dig deep so we could send a clear message in terms of this fight that we are contributors and we want to make a difference in the lives of those who are fighting every day, not just to live a quality of life, but just to live.

[00:51:15] So thank you, Mr. Speaker. The delegate from Newport News, Delegate Price. Mr. Speaker, I rise for an introduction. Douglas, the floor. Thank you, Mr. Speaker and members. Today we have with us in the gallery special guests visiting from the Minority Political Leadership Institute, and I ask them to please stand.

[00:51:34] This is a division of the L. Douglas Wilder School of Government and Public Affairs at the Grace E. Harris Leadership Institute at Virginia Commonwealth University. I had the pleasure of speaking to this group this year in November, and they asked thoughtful questions and are doing important work toward leadership development for those focused on issues important to minority communities including community economics, political climate, civic engagement and equity.

[00:52:05] MPLI offers insights and concepts regarding personal leadership, policy and legislative processes to cultivate a deeper understanding of legacy, responsible stewardship, public service and integrity for future leaders from across the Commonwealth. Participants here today are not only learners, but also are leaders in their current fields and will continue to do work to shape Virginia's policies and progress for years to come. To the 2026 cohort of the Minority Political Leadership Institute, I hope it will be the pleasure of the body to give them a warm

[00:52:40] house welcome. Welcome. Welcome to the Capitol today. Delegate from Shenandoah, Delegate Pence. Thank you, Mr. Speaker. I rise for an announcement.

[00:52:57] Delegate has the floor. Thank you, Mr. Speaker. It seems fitting today that I'd like to remind my colleagues that agriculture is the state's number one industry. And the number one organization advocating for agriculture is having their centennial celebration next Thursday, February 26th.

[00:53:13] Mr. Speaker, Farm Bureau is celebrating their 100th anniversary. 100 years ago, the Speaker of the House was Democrat Thomas William Osland. And the 50th governor was Harry F. Byrd, Sr. And that year, the General Assembly passed 584 new laws, how things have changed.

[00:53:32] Milk was 58 cents a gallon, bread was a dime a loaf, eggs were 56 cents a dozen, and bacon was 50 cents per pound. So, Mr. Speaker, you could have breakfast for a family of six for $1.75. Now that won't even buy you a cup of coffee. That's right. So in celebration of Farm Bureau Centennial, they're going to have a bus provided to take members of the General Assembly to their reception next Thursday at 5 p.m.

[00:53:57] It'll be at the 9th Street Road there right between the parking garage and General Assembly Building. And they'll be featuring a reception featuring samplings from 14 districts all over the state. And I hope that you would enjoy participating with us, and we'll have you back here by 645 in time to put on your bowling shoes for the bipartisan bowling event that night.

[00:54:21] So thank you, Mr. Speaker. The delegate from Virginia Beach, Delegate Converse Fowler. Thank you, Mr. Speaker. I rise for an introduction. Delegate has the floor. Thank you, Mr. Speaker. Mr. Speaker, joining us in the gallery today is a group of Virginia Beach residents here for their Day of Action.

[00:54:38] Mr. Speaker, in this group are members of the Virginia Beach Branch of the NAACP, Affordable Virginia, and Stand Up Now. I ask that they please rise if they are able. Mr. Speaker, these organizations and committed community members are focused on advancing equality, affordability, and a better life for all Virginians.

[00:54:59] I hope that the members of the House will join me in giving them a warm House welcome. Welcome. Welcome to the Capitol today. Pursuant to House Rule 30, the journal shall reflect that the following members are away on pressing personal business on a granted leave from today's session.

[00:55:19] Delegates Carroll, Clark, Maldonado, Rasul, and Ward. Clerk shall announce the next order of business. Mr. Speaker, the second portion of the morning hour reserve for announcements of member

requests to move anything from an uncontested to a contested calendar. I'm not aware of any. Clerk will announce the next order of business.

[00:55:35] Third portion of the morning hour reserve for member requests for an election to go by for the day. Similarly, I am not aware of any such requests. Clerk will announce the next order of business. And the fourth and final portion of the morning hour on this Friday is reserved for points of personal privilege. Kindly use your request to speak button to get into the queue. The delegate from Virginia Beach, Delegate Tater.

[00:55:54] Thank you, Mr. Speaker. I rise for a point of personal privilege. The delegate has the floor. Thank you, Mr. Speaker. I rise to honor a giant of a man, Delegate Barry Knight. He was my friend, mentor, colleague, and brother in Christ. I've known Barry for almost 20 years, and there are simply no words adequate to express my love and admiration for such an extraordinary person in just two minutes.

[00:56:19] But I want to share a few things that speak to why he meant so much to me. First, I've always believed that one of the truest measures of a man is how he treats and speaks about his wife. Barry adored Paula. He was a family-first man, and that began with his beloved wife.

[00:56:37] I love that about him, and it is an incredible legacy he has passed on to his three boys. Second, you can tell a great deal about a person by how they handle adversity. Over the past couple of years in this body, Barry faced significant challenges. I spoke with him often during that time.

[00:56:55] He was never angry or bitter. He would remind me almost routinely that he had his family, his true friends, and his faith, and that was enough. He was not defined by his position in the General Assembly, and he knew who he was, and he had his priorities straight.

[00:57:11] And finally, he showed me how to live and how to die. He was taken far too soon, and his death still doesn't make sense to me. And yet, it is a stark reminder that we are here for just a brief time. The decisions we make, the way we treat people, it all matters.

[00:57:28] I'm reminded of King David's words in Psalm 39. Lord, remind me how brief my time on earth will be. Remind me that my days are numbered, how fleeting my life is. You have made my life no longer than the width of my hand, and my entire lifetime is just a moment to you.

[00:57:44] At best, each of us is just but a breath. Barry's life was fleeting, but I believe that when he left his earthly home, he did so with his integrity, his character, and his kindness. and his forgiving heart fully intact. Thank you, Mr. Speaker. Delegate from Fauquier County, Delegate Weber.

[00:58:20] Thank you, Mr. Speaker. Mr. Speaker, I rise for a point of personal privilege. Delegate has the floor. Mr. Speaker, today his desk in this chamber sits empty, and that emptiness carries weight.

[00:58:48] He was the old guard, the grizzled lion, the kind of man whose respect was earned and not easily given. So was his loyalty.

[00:59:07] Barry Knight was cut from a different cloth, a farmer first, A man shaped by hard seasons and long days. He had seen the world evolve, policy trends come and go, watched politics change.

[00:59:27] But he never lost hold of where he came from. The hard days of his youth, the discipline of the work before dawn, the understanding that nothing worth building comes easy.

[00:59:45] That life, lived hard and lived well, became a steady hand for this commonwealth. He produced food before he produced budgets. He understood stewardship long before he chaired appropriations. And when he became the senior delegate from Virginia Beach and chairman of appropriations, he did not view power as something to wield for show.

[01:00:09] He understood it as responsibility. He respected the numbers because he respected the people behind those numbers. Barry was a student of the game, Mr. Speaker. He knew the inquiries of finance and the state budget not because it was glamorous, but because it mattered.

[01:00:29] When he spoke, you listened. You really didn't have a choice. There was always something to learn from a man who had both dirt under his fingernails and command of the balance sheet. He was larger than life.

[01:00:47] So was his love for his family. And he enjoyed being larger than life. The stories usually involved a helicopter ride, a hunting trip, Buddy Fowler, or fishing somewhere most of us had only read about. But the story that always makes me smile, I shared on social media.

[01:01:09] I got a call from Barry one day asking what I knew about Deutz engines. He was looking at a tractor and wanted my opinion. I told him I thought they were solid engines, dependable, low maintenance. He said, good, I'm flying up there to take a look at a tractor. And sure enough, later that week, Barry flew his helicopter from Virginia Beach to Front Royal, landed nearby, and went over to the Rural King to look at a tractor, which he promptly bought.

[01:01:40] Now, the folks at the Rural King thought this was the coolest thing they'd ever seen. The manager was like, Mike, we're on the map, because he flew up in a helicopter to buy a tractor. But that was Barrett, a man who worked hard, a man who carried enormous responsibility, a man who believed that when life is tough, you ought to have a little fun too.

[01:02:06] He understood power and the responsibility to wield it. He understood work and the dignity in it. He understood that leadership is not noise, but steadiness. Barrett was truly one of a kind, and now his fight is done.

[01:02:28] But the mark he left on this chamber and on this commonwealth will not fade. His lessons remain. His example remains. And for those of us who had the privilege of serving alongside him and call him friend, we are better for it.

[01:02:51] Rest easy, Mr. Chairman. You earned it. Thank you, Mr. Speaker. The delegate from Virginia Beach, Delegate Fagans.

[01:03:16] Mr. Speaker, I rise for a point of personal privilege. The delegate has the floor. Today, Mr. Speaker, we've had the opportunity to discuss and remember many Virginia Beach individuals who have trailblazed, and I want to continue that as we talk about also in terms of Black History Month.

[01:03:37] I'd like to make sure that we're going to honor today, as we've talked about, Delegate Barry Knight. We're also going to be honoring another trailblazer in Virginia Beach's history. That is firefighter Anthony Cook, also known as Tony. And I would like to speak to that motion.

[01:03:53] Devin has the floor. Mr. Speaker, in 1976, Anthony, Tony Cook, or as Tony as he was known, he became the first black career firefighter in Virginia Beach Firefighter Department history. And I just like for everyone to kind of think about that. 1976 is when we had our first black firefighter.

[01:04:14] That only wasn't, that just wasn't a hiring decision. It was a turning point in Virginia Beach history. Before he even stepped foot and became a firefighter in Virginia Beach, Tony served our nation in the United States Army, including a tour in Vietnam, where he had already faced danger abroad.

[01:04:33] And when he returned home, he chose to continue serving this community as he stepped into a profession that he loved and that many served across this nation, the profession of firefighting. But it was a profession that was still grappling with many issues, especially around integration.

[01:04:51] And we cannot tell the full story of serving as a firefighter without also acknowledging some of the broader history, especially during the civil rights movements. In cities like Birmingham, where those same fire hoses that were turned to turn off fires were unfortunately sometimes used on those in civil rights movement.

[01:05:11] Inside many fire stations around this country during the time and over the past history, the integration of individuals was often met with resistance. They had separate spaces, limited advancement, and quiet hostility where those were realities that were reserved for many of the African-American firefighters.

[01:05:32] Individuals like Tony face that. The fire service, like America though, has had to confront its own shortcomings. Tony walked into that reality with courage and discipline, even on one of his first emergency calls where he had a resident call and he went out to go to it. Tony was unable to provide service to that individual because that individual would not allow Tony to come into their home because of his skin. Imagine that. Imagine your duty and being called to your duty and not being

[01:06:07] able to render care simply because of the color of your skin. But Tony persevered. He continued to be what he was always known as calm, professional, always ready to serve. He allowed his character and his competence and his qualifications to overcome any type of prejudice he may have encountered. Ten years into his career, though, when he had another opportunity, there was a three alarm apartment fire that left four children trapped inside. Tony ran into the smoke, lifted

[01:06:42] two children under his arms and guided the others out. And for that, Mr. Speaker, he was awarded the Medal of Honor. After 25 years of service, Tony, he retired in 2001, a master firefighter. And when he passed away in 2016, at the age of 66, the pathway that he blazed was clear, and he was properly memorized, remembered. Individuals like Tony, they helped not just individuals in Virginia Beach, but individuals across the Commonwealth. Individuals like my father, who became the first

[01:07:20] black fire captain at Norfolk International Airport Fire Department. So, Mr. Speaker, during this Black History Month, when we're called to remember the full arc of these stories, from a time when fire hoses were unfortunately used against those fighting for civil rights, to a time when departments finally became more inclusive, that those individuals were able to be reflective of the communities that they serve. Those individuals like Tony helped to have progress, because the progress didn't happen by accident, Mr. Speaker. It happened because

[01:07:54] trailblazers like Tony were able to move forward, they were able to endure, and they were to exceed, to excel. Happy Black History Month, Mr. Speaker. Delegate from Fairfax, Delegate Keyes Gamara. Thank you, Mr. Speaker. I rise for a point of personal privilege. Delegate has the floor.

[01:08:26] Thank you. Today, Mr. Speaker, I also rise in honor of Black History Month, and I simply want to say that I am so very grateful. Yesterday I had an entirely different speech. I was going to ask this

question, where did that come from? And I was going to look back at history and talk about how it so often and too often repeats itself. But as I was driving to this building at about 6.50 a.m. for a 7.30 committee, I think we can work on that, I was overwhelmed with gratefulness.

[01:09:06] I knew the history of how black folks had been demeaned compared to animals. I knew how we had enshrined certain ideas into the laws, especially Virginia's 1902 Constitution, which was specifically written to remove the black vote of black men.

[01:09:26] And that Constitution stayed in place until 1971. And it was so effective, Mr. Speaker, that at the time it was written, about 144,000 black men were voting. And just a few years later, it was less than 10,000. The Klan participated in that effort by offering intimidation showing up not just at voting places, but also at people's homes to make sure what the rule of law was that they were enforcing. And so when I hear people like Kristi Noem saying that ICE agents should rightfully be at our voting places, that they

[01:10:05] just there to make sure that we elect the right people, I'm reminded of our history. I was going through all of this in my mind as I was preparing today, as I thought I had everything all written down. And in my mind's eye, I saw my mother's hands. I remembered how she woke me up and encouraged me and made sure she told me my history herself. She didn't just talk about the chains of slavery and the scarred history that we all know about, but she told me about the great courage

[01:10:40] of many people that we never really talked about in school. She taught me the poem of Paul Lawrence Dunbar that said, I'm still climbing on these stairs with nails and tacks on it, but I'm still climbing. Today, I want to thank all the mamas and the daddies and so many more of the unsung heroes who have stood up for all of us. There are so many like my uncle Stacy, who was one of the

[01:11:14] first people who took me to fish. I was maybe five or six. I got in his car and he pulled on the side of the road and I didn't see any water. I saw grass. He pulled out his fishing gear and his machete. I was as close as that man to that man as I could get because he cut a path to that fishing hope and that day as i look back i realized that he was showing me i didn't have to be afraid because there had been people who went ahead of me and prepared the way he was one of my unsung

[01:11:50] heroes and i'm sure we all have many like that and then there was my elementary school teacher miss rose with the bouffant hair and she told me i could bring anything i wanted to the show and towel. I took her up on my word and I brought in an article about the Black Panthers. She had this look of glint, of glare, of joy on her face when she turned to the kids and said, now I'm going to give you a copy of this. Take it home and discuss it with your parents. I came the next day waiting

[01:12:29] to hear what everybody would say. And each and every one of them said, my parents said, we cannot talk about that. I have never seen Ms. Rose get so indignant. She got up out of her seat and banged on her desk and said, if you can talk about Jesse James, you can talk about the Black Panthers.

[01:12:51] Now, I didn't think Jesse James and the Black Panthers were the same or even equivalent, but what she did was remove the boundaries off of education and told me, Karen, go learn, explore. She removed some boundaries, Mr. Speaker, and for that, she is one of my unsung heroes she also points out some of the things that we're hearing today you know that's too negative to talk about if you go to philadelphia you'll see that they just put some plaques back up that were removed because the white house said it wasn't nice to talk about it was talking about

[01:13:31] slavery and george washington just happened to be the one that had the slaves unsung heroes my dad i have to say was is one of my heroes because as a teenager i was driving home from church and my car broke down and back in those days I'm ashamed to say we didn't have a cell phone so I started walking and I saw a nice neighbor she let me use her phone and I called my dad and just after that as I was walking to the meeting point I noticed there was a truck following me with two white men

[01:14:05] in it starting to taunt me and call me names and I wasn't sure what their plan was but I knew where I was supposed to meet my daddy so I kept walking and when I got to my high school they sped up to meet me and I ran down the hill and I figured they were going around to come meet me but I turned around and ran back up that hill and I saw my daddy and I'm just grateful that he is one of my unsung heroes because there were people along the way with no names that wanted to make sure that we

[01:14:37] were safe and we made it home so many folks that just did their part not just the Rosa Parks who sat on the bus but the people who refused to get on it until people got the point so I want to thank those folks in our community who without notice did the things that were necessary to prepare for the next generation to make a way for us. They knew the history of voter intimidation but they voted anyway. They knew education was being withheld but built HBCUs and other organizations

[01:15:13] and if you're like me you went to church and got black history. They stood up for us and now Mr. Speaker. We see history repeating itself again, but I'm just grateful for all those unsung heroes who made it possible for us to be here and to continue to fight for democracy, our future, and the next generation. Happy Black History Month.

[01:15:45] Cook will call a calendar. Calendar for this Friday, February 20th, 2026, for the Virginia House of Delegates.

[01:16:01] Page 1 of the printed calendar, first category, only a live category today, House Bill with Senate Amendment. House Bill 29 is legislation to amend and reenact after 725 of the Acts of Assembly of 2025, which appropriated the public revenues for two years, ending respectively on June 30, 2025 and June 30, 2026, as well as including language to amend and reenact portions of the Code of Virginia.

[01:16:23] This legislation originally passed the House February 10th, subsequently passed the Senate with amendments. Those Senate amendments are now before the body. They are available to the members via IHOD, to the public, via the legislative information systems. And as I said, they are now before you.

[01:16:39] Delegate from Prince William, Delegate Torrey. Thank you, Mr. Speaker. Mr. Speaker, I move that the House agree to the Senate amendments to House Bill 29, and I would like to speak to those amendments. The delegate has the floor. Mr. Speaker, House Bill HB 29 passed on February 9th.

[01:16:55] Today it is before us with minor modifications and one substantive addition. The new language in the bill is reflected in item 365, number 1S, and it relates to resuming the Commonwealth's participation in the Regional Greenhouse Gas Initiative.

[01:17:12] A technical change also is made to item 0, which inserts the code sections referred to in items 365 into the title of the bill. Also included is clarifying language in the 15th enactment, stating that the provisions of this act relating to tax conformity supersedes language included when the budget was adopted last year.

[01:17:33] And lastly, there are changes to the congressional districts as outlined in item 4-14, number 1. Mr. Speaker, I move passage of the Senate Amendments. Delegate from Scott County, Delegate Kilgore. Mr. Speaker, I would encourage a no vote on this bill.

[01:17:52] Thank you, Mr. Speaker. Shall the Senate amendments be agreed to?

[01:18:09] Clerk will close the roll. Ayes 59, noes 35. Ayes 59, noes 35. The Senate amendment is adopted. Mr. Speaker, that completes work on today's calendar. So on House Rule 51, the House is returned to the morning hour.

[01:18:25] Does the clerk have any additional announcements or communications? No communications, simply announcements as we look ahead to the remainder of the afternoon as we get ready for a budget on Sunday and next week. The only legislative meetings that will be happening this afternoon, the Committee for Courts of Justice is meeting 15 minutes upon adjournment of the House.

[01:18:48] They're going to be in House Committee Room C, so that's Courts of Justice Criminal Subcommittee of committees foregoing its time. So they're going to meet 15 minutes in House Room C over on the second floor, 15 minutes after adjournment, their Committee on Appropriations will be meeting up on the 12th floor to work whatever's on their docket.

[01:19:10] Those are the only two legislative meetings going. Then as we prepare for budget next week, the Committee on Appropriations will be meeting this Sunday at 1 o'clock. General Assembly and whatnot will be open two hours prior to that for the public.

[01:19:27] But appropriations will be at 1 o'clock to report out amendments to the new by forthcoming, upcoming biannual budget. Then looking ahead to Monday, February 23rd, education, nothing's going on with that committee or subcommittee.

[01:19:45] CC&T subcommittee is not meeting, but the full committee on communications, technology, and innovation will be meeting at 10 o'clock in House Committee Room C on the second floor. So that's the only meeting on Monday, legislative meeting, and then in preparation for a convening at noon, the Democratic talks meet at 11.15 on Monday, Republicans 11.30 on Monday, Democrats in House Room 1, Republicans in House Room 2.

[01:20:13] That is all of the announcements I have right now. Delegate from Alexandria, Delegate Herring. Mr. Speaker, I move that when the House adjourns today, it adjourned to reconvene on Monday at 12 noon. Delegate from Alexandria. Delegate hearing moves that when the House adjourned today, it adjourned to reconvene Monday at 12 noon.

[01:20:29] As many in favor, the motion will say aye. Those opposed, no. The motion is agreed to. The Delegate from Alexandria. Delegate hearing. Mr. Speaker, I move that the House do now adjourn. Delegate from Alexandria. Delegate hearing moves that the House do now adjourn. As many in favor, the motion will say aye. Those opposed, no. The motion is agreed to. The House stands adjourned until Monday at 12 noon.



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